in the post-1975 period of India being portrayed as a source of threat. A soft loan of US$500 million has also been extended for defence purchases, which may help Bangladesh reduce its heavy dependence on Chinese arms and equipment.[11] India has also started conducting military exercises with the armies of Nepal and Bangladesh and naval exercises with Sri Lanka to enhance “interoperability” and “counter-insurgency” cooperation.

A distinguishing feature of Modi’s neighbourhood policy has been the emphasis on the use of soft power. In this respect, India’s existing cultural policy has been institutionalised and strengthened. Special place has been accorded to the promotion of Yoga and Buddhist linkages in relation to Sri Lanka and Nepal. Prime Minister Modi himself has been visiting Hindu and Buddhist temples during his visits to these countries. International Yoga Day has been celebrated with considerable fanfare in these countries. This aspect is explored in further detail in the chapter by Xavier in this volume. Moreover, India has come forward to help its neighbours in disaster relief. It was the first to reach Nepal in the wake of the massive earthquake of April–May 2015. During floods in Bangladesh and Nepal in August–September 2016, and in Sri Lanka during May 2017 and again in February 2019, India rushed to offer assistance while itself suffering from massive floods.

The outcome

As mentioned at the beginning of this chapter, the “neighbourhood first” policy did not yield completely satisfactory results, notwithstanding the efforts made by India, as discussed previously. While the “India cares” aspect of the policy initially generated enthusiasm in the